

Team-Based Leadership Paper

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Introduction

This paper examines what team-leadership is in the context of a church. Specifically, this paper examines 7 attributes of team-leadership, and 9 post-modern characteristics.

Attributes

Covenanting Team

A covenanting team is a team that makes covenants, and follows through on them. These covenants are not strict, or supposed to suffocate a person, but supposed to unite everyone toward a common goal and purpose.

“One year, the music ministry received a larger portion of the budget increase.”¹ In this case, there was an issue between parties for money - one party wanted all the money for themselves.

In these cases, we must understand the following quote of what covenanting is about: it “establishes covenants with us as a way of uniting us in fellowship with God. These covenants initiated by God are formed out of the depths of God's love, grace, and forbearance.”

The covenant can be written or verbal; however, I prefer written because we can refer to it again and again and have it posted on our office. Once we have a written agreement, we need to commit to it - each of us. As tensions rise, we can refer back to our agreement.

We need to allow for “venting” and expressing “frustration.” We need to give everyone time to develop a covenant that reflects the hearts and minds of everyone. It may take months to produce.

Allow people to be “honest” and “self-disclose.” If there is improper handling of the finances, allow people to have the grace to speak that they have done so wrongfully. This acceptance allows people to agree with each other as a team.

¹ George Cladis, *Leading the Team-Based Church: How Pastors and Church Staffs Can Grow Together into a Powerful Fellowship of Leaders* (San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, 1999), Kindle edition.

“Acknowledge sin.” We can realize that we are all sinners and we will encounter sin from our team members. “Egos flare up” and people “feel anxious.” We have to accommodate for this.

When writing the covenant, be specific and avoid small details.

Re-read the covenant often.

“Orient new team members.” Have them understand in advance what this team is all about before they join.

“Be gracious.” Covenants are meant to make people happy and loving - rather than angry and forced.

Visionary Team

“Effective ministry teams are those that cast a vision that unites people around a God-given cause.” What this means is that good teams are those that have everyone going toward a goal because of a cause - a reason to exist - a purpose for going forward.

I want to examine what is a cause. A cause is the first step in establishing an organization, and thus the foundation of the vision. A cause is why we want to work hard toward something and the goal that we want to achieve.

It can be that a “congregation can be fragmented into ministry centers that eventually compete and even war with each other.” In this case, we need a vision to unite us back together. In the words of the text, ministry areas “loosely held together and competing with one another need a strong common vision to unite them.” You see, when the going gets tough, we need to remember why we are in this fight.

For example, when I was in conflict with my family, I would say, “This is my family. They are everything to me. I’m willing to do anything for them.” And this backbone of family allowed me to endure the many tribulations that come from being with people so closely. Similarly, when an organization is in conflict, we need to understand why we are doing this fundamentally, in order to continue going forward and overcome the hardship.

An example is Voice Of the Martyrs. This is just a fictional example, but let’s say that there are office workers at this organization who are fighting over who get the next paycheck. By fighting over this, they are not able to do the work that is going to save lives on the front-lines. They need to know what they are fighting for and toss aside these petty arguments.

Individuals must “articulate clearly what it is God uniquely calls them to be and do.” And so we see that every team is composed of individuals, and each individual has a calling that contributes to the cause and vision of the team.

Therefore, each individual must be able to clearly say what his purpose and calling is - as an individual, and how he wants to contribute to the team.

An example is me, who can contribute with Computer Science to my business. But I need to understand that God called me to be a leader and a people-unifier in order to understand how I fit in the structure of the organization.

Culture-Creating Team

One of the things that the book talks about is creating images and symbols that create culture. For example, it says, it is an “unconscious and involuntary, drawing in part upon images lodged long ago in the human struggle for meaning.”

I really like how the text says that it is a “human struggle for meaning,” but I don’t see how there is images and symbols in every culture.

You see, when I think of culture, I don’t think of just some logo. I think of the actual atmosphere and environment of the place that I go to work and do my ministry in.

Is it light? Happy? Joyful? Productive? Drag? Depressing? Tension? Competitive? These are the words that come to mind when I think of culture, and I would like to add it to the explanation of this attribute of team.

Later in the chapter, he talks of “loyalty and effectiveness.” This is more of what I would expect and think about.

An example of bad culture is: “We fear that the corporate culture is entrenched with aggressive and hostile behaviors and structures we would not want to emulate in the church.”

Collaborative Team

The author speaks of “Lone Ranger Heroics,” and people that try to solve everything and handle everything by themselves. We realize that we need to work together as a team and share each other’s burdens. We should “experience the beauty of Spirit-given synergy.”

Trusting Team

He says that all teams must have trust and must “They must work to keep it.” It’s an interesting thing that he says we must try to keep it, because it is easy for us to lose trust and create a culture of mistrust. It is almost impossible to regain trust once it has been clearly broken by betrayal or something terrible.

Empowering Team

The author says that teams must empower as they do in the postmodern world, rather than control as they do in the modern and previous era.

People with training should not do ministry by themselves, but rather they should use their training “for helping people reflect on the nature of God and the practice of ministry.” In other words, the top guys need to raise up co-workers and co-leaders.

Learning Team

Teams are never static - they are dynamic and changing. Thus they must be “growing and open to new discoveries. They have an insatiable appetite to learn.” Without learning, we do nothing. Learning causes us to keep up with the pace and to improve our standing. We need to know in order to do. We cannot do without knowing. We must learn first.

Post-modern characteristics

Modernism

Modernism is organizing and standardizing reality into one system (Location 302).

Modernism is a competition and hierarchy that forced people and made them cogs (Location 302).

Post-modernism

It is relativism in pluralism that results in a variegated behaviors and values that Christians don't like (Location 307).

1) Organism

Authority is based on trust and is visionary (Location 312).

Modernism does not grows fluidly and recruits people to cookie cutter roles (Location 319). It is not so much controlling but on “learning about it, discovering the interaction of its parts” (Location 322).

2) Hierarchical Reduced

This is flatter structures that “draw out the innovation of all work group members not just of a few” (location 329).

3) Authority is on trust

We do not force people to listen to us no matter what - we show them we have good character and make them understand we are God’s people to lead them with authority that is right and good for them and for everyone.

4) Effective Leadership is Visionary

We seek to lead with a vision that aims towards a high calling that God gives us, rather than just trying to get by day-by-day and make money on the way.

5) Life and Work are Spiritually Rooted

We seek God in everything in our lives, even in our family life and in our work. God causes us to live a faithful life of obedience and love in all areas of our lives.

6) Structures are smaller; Networks bigger

We are interconnected and can help each other and use each other’s strengths. We are not locked in a format or grid

7) Innovation is Rewarded

We seek to reward those who want to improve things, not just give money for doing your job. We want to make things improve and grow.

8) Work follows Gifts, Gifts are Used Collaboratively

Gifts are used for work. We don't work to achieve some calling, our calling propels us to do our work. And we use our gifts to serve one another and cause each other to benefit and grow.

9) Denominations have ended

I disagree with the author. In Korea, denominations are alive and well. But we are not locked in one denomination - there are many to choose from.

Covenanting Team Rationale

The Biblical rationale for building a team is found in the verses on the body of Christ. Also, love one another. Ephesians has a lot of "one another's." The Bible and God covenants us in a relationship with God and with each other so that we do what is honest and good for each other and for the world.

Building an Empowering Team

Building a team that empowers people is to use their strengths for the benefit of the company and church. We need to view people as people and as people with callings and gifts from God that need to live out their lives and their calling in their own unique way.

We cannot just force them to fit in the mold.